, print layout

Iris

Monthly Chemical Trends

EDITION

February 2026

Published 2026-04-23 A Cefic publication

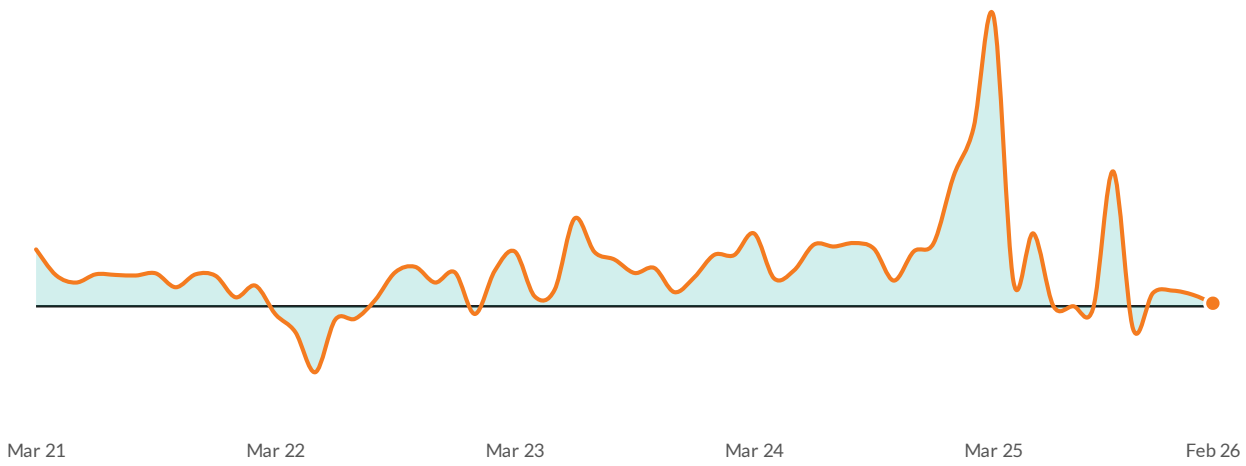
Data: Eurostat, Comext. © 2026 Cefic, European Chemical Industry Council.

OVERVIEW

Key takeaway

EU27 CHEMICAL EXPORTS	PRODUCTION INDEX	PRODUCER PRICES	CHEMICAL SALES
€34.5 bn	79.3	117.2	90.8
-42.1%	-3.9%	-2.8%	-7.5%
Jan-Feb 2026 vs 2025	Feb 2026, 2021=100	Feb 2026, YoY	Jan 2026, YoY

EU27 chemical trade balance, 60-month context.



Source: Cefic analysis based on Eurostat Comext data (2021-2026)

The EU27 chemical industry reported a 42.1% decline in export value in the first two months of 2026, heavily influenced by pre-tariff front-loading in February 2025 that created an abnormal comparison base. Chemical output fell 3.9% year-on-year in February, reaching 79.3 on the 2021 index, while remaining 18% below pre-crisis levels (2014-2019 average). Against a normalised 2024 base, the underlying export decline approximates 10%.

MACRO BRIEF

Production, prices, sales

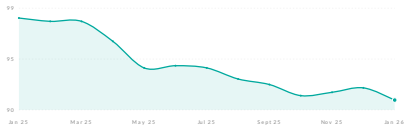
Output index, EU27 chemicals (2021=100)

79.3 -3.8% since Jan 25

Producer prices, EU27 chemicals (2021=100)

117.2 -1.8% since Jan 25

Chemical sales, EU27 (2021=100)



90.8 -7.5% since Jan 25

EU27 chemical production declined by 3.9% in February 2026 compared to February 2025, with the index reaching 79.3 (2021=100). Chemical production underperformed total manufacturing, which declined by just 0.4% in February. Pharmaceuticals fell more, at 8.6%, while basic metals dropped 0.7% and motor vehicles gained 2.0%.

EU27 chemical producer prices declined by 2.8% in February 2026 compared to February 2025, reaching an index level of 117.2. The Netherlands experienced the steepest price decline at 9.2%, followed by Belgium (5.5%) and France (3.0%).

EU27 chemical sales declined 7.5% in January 2026 to 90.8, continuing the sector's compression against the 2021 baseline.

DRILL-DOWN

Structural partners, US / CN / GB

United States US	China CN	United Kingdom GB
€3.56 bn	€1.40 bn	€2.13 bn
-72.5% (-9.39 bn)	-7.3% (-0.11 bn)	+4.9% (+0.10 bn)
19.6% of total exports	7.7% of total exports	11.7% of total exports

From January to February 2026, EU27 chemical exports decreased by 42.1% in value in comparison to the same period in 2025. Exports amounted to €34.5 bn, down by €25.1 bn compared to 2025. The United States alone contributed €19 bn of the decrease, reflecting the unwinding of front-loaded February 2025 shipments ahead of anticipated tariff actions.

EU27 chemical imports decreased by 12.0% in value to €33.5 bn. Imports from China rose 4.8% to €4.4 bn, and imports from the United States rose 4.7% to €3.7 bn. UK imports declined 13.3% to €1.5 bn.

APPENDIX

Full edition text

EU27 chemical exports fall 42% in February, distorted by anomalous 2025 base

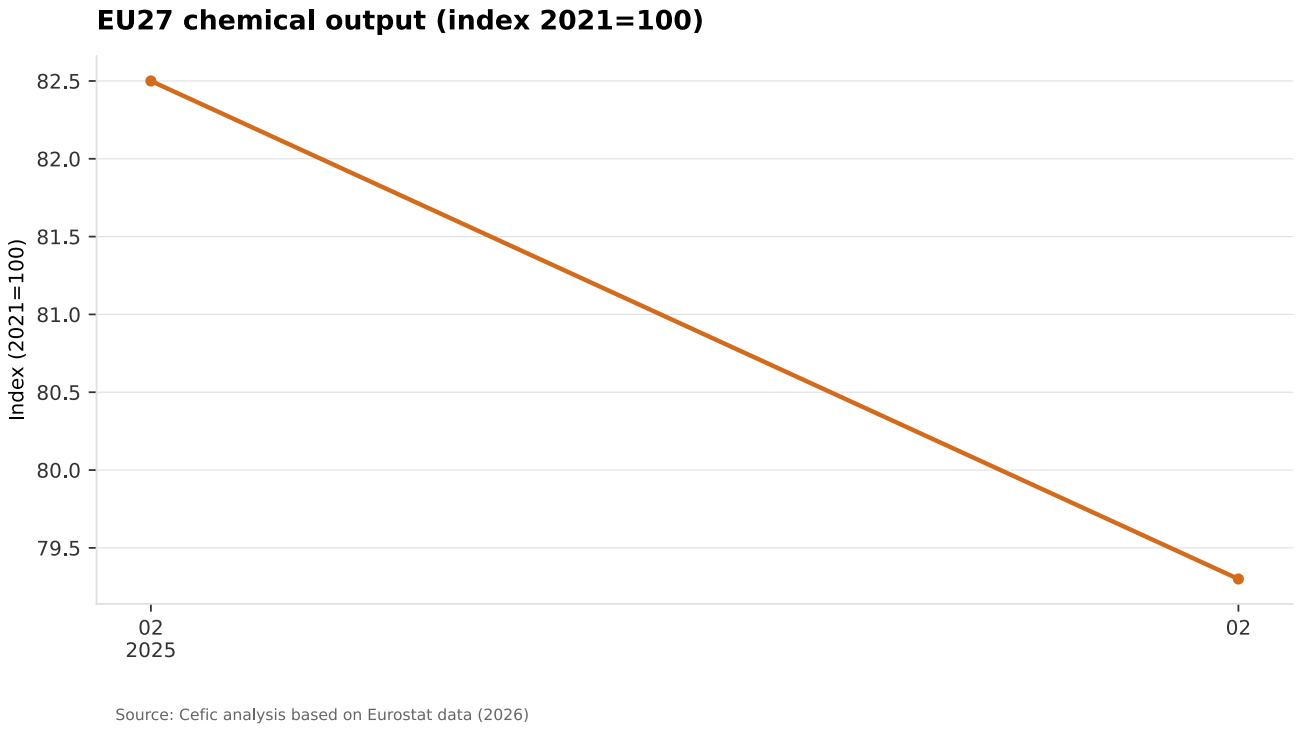
The EU27 chemical industry reported a 42.1% decline in export value in the first two months of 2026, heavily influenced by pre-tariff front-loading in February 2025 that created an abnormal comparison base. Chemical output fell 3.9% year-on-year in February, reaching 79.3 on the 2021 index, while remaining 18% below pre-crisis levels (2014–2019 average). Producer prices declined 2.8% year-on-year, reflecting persistent deflationary pressures across the sector. The trade balance collapsed to €0.2 bn from €12.4 bn in early 2025, driven by the export contraction and resilient import flows from China (+4.8%) and the United States (+4.7%). With the top-5 export partners accounting for 50% of value, trade flows remain concentrated despite the structural disruption, while volume exports fell less sharply at 17.4%, indicating a shift toward lower-value product categories.

EU27 chemical output down 3.9% in February, 18% below pre-crisis levels

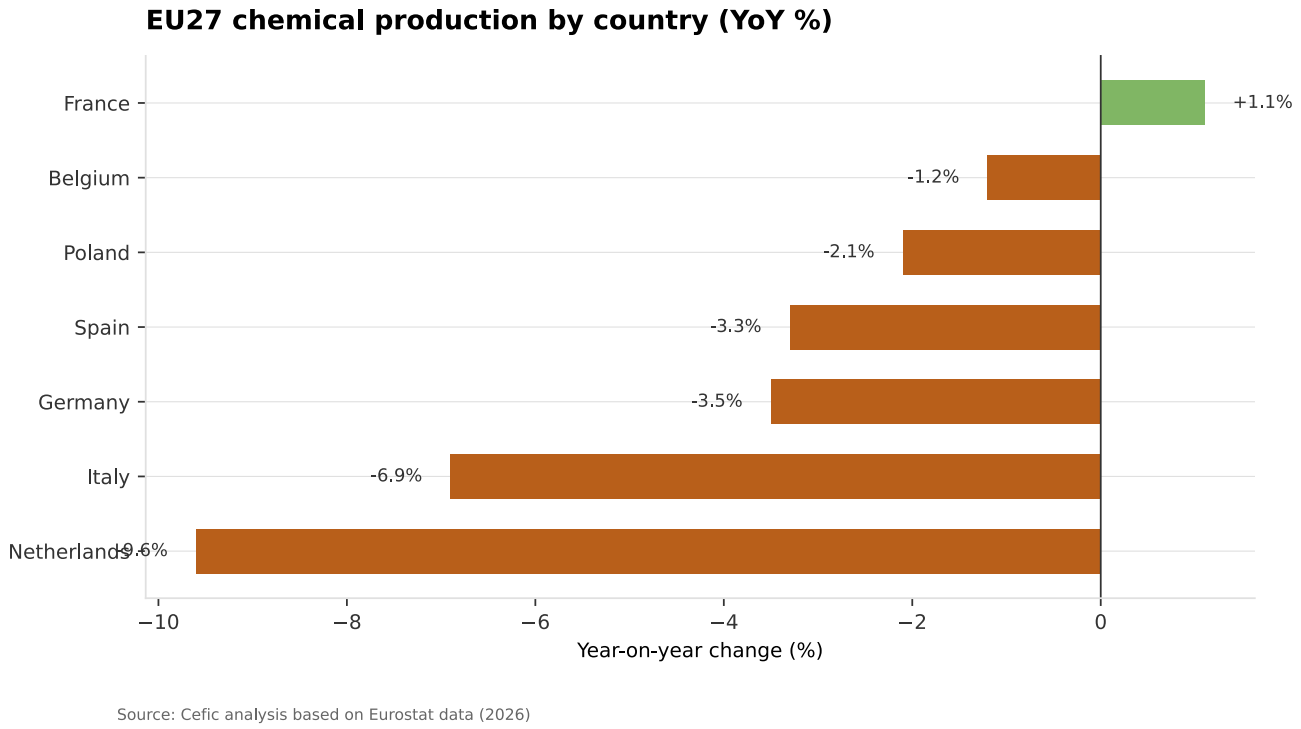
EU27 chemical production declined by 3.9% in February 2026 compared to February 2025, with the index reaching 79.3 (2021=100). In the first two months of 2026, chemical output averaged 79.1, down 1.7% compared to the same period in 2025. The sector remains 18% below pre-crisis levels (2014–2019 average).

Chemical production underperformed total manufacturing, which declined by just 0.4% in February. Pharmaceuticals fell more, at 8.6%, while basic metals dropped 0.7% and motor vehicles gained 2.0%.

Country trends show significant variation across the EU27. The Netherlands experienced the steepest decline at 9.6%, followed by Italy (6.9%) and Germany (3.5%). Spain fell 3.3%, Poland declined 2.1%, and Belgium dropped 1.2%. Only France gained, at 1.1%.



Source: Cefic analysis based on Eurostat data (2026)



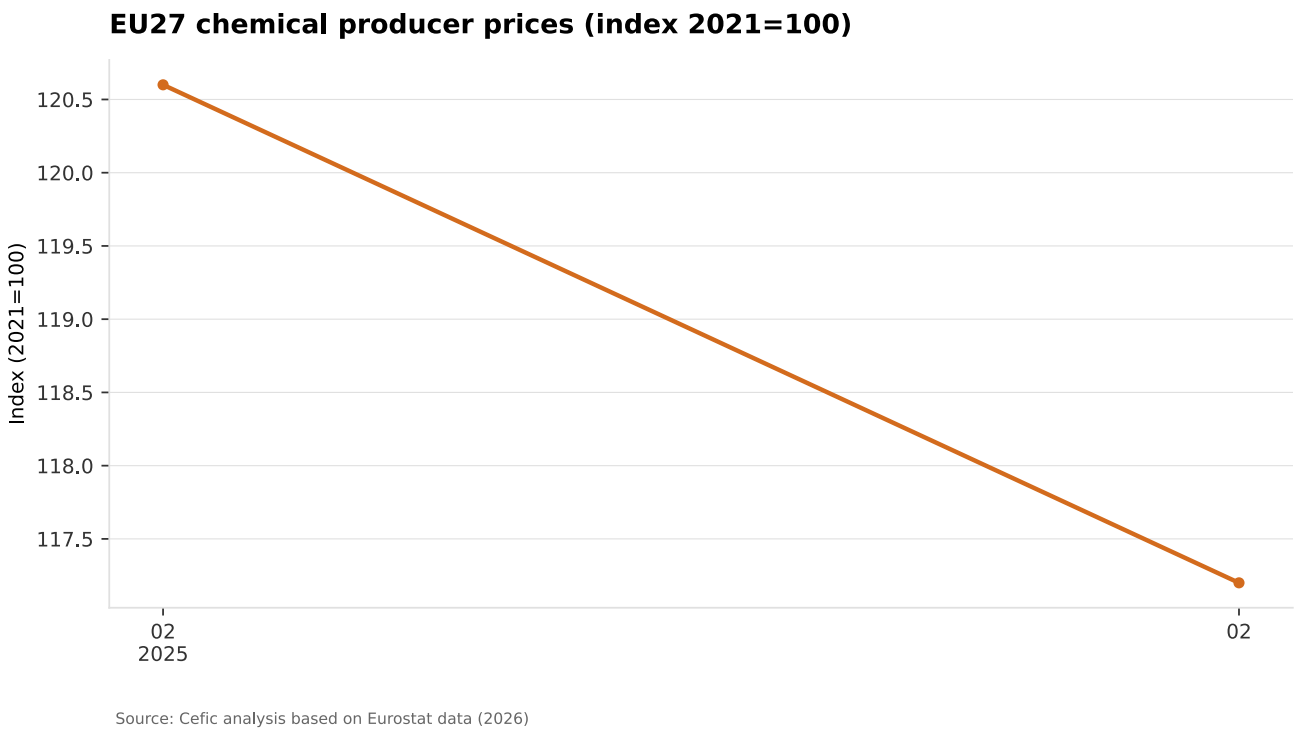
Source: Cefic analysis based on Eurostat data (2026)

EU27 chemical prices down 2.8% year-on-year in February 2026

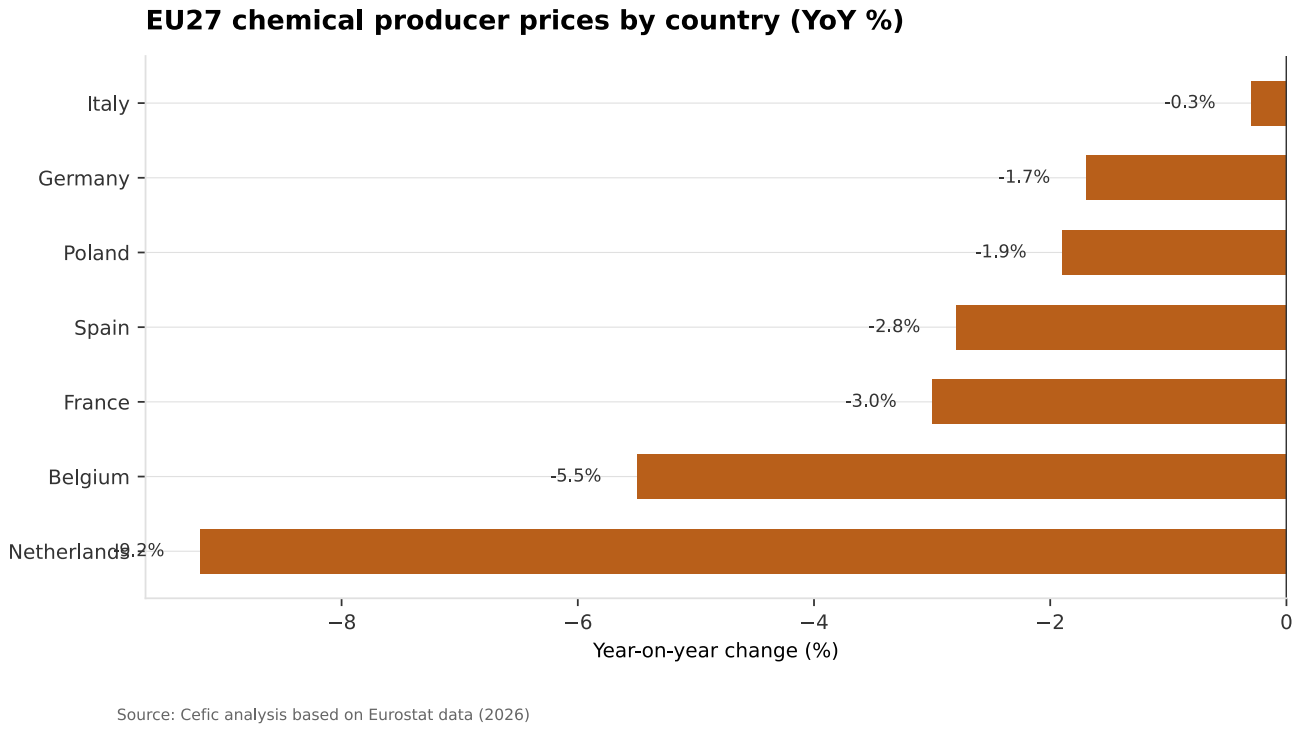
EU27 chemical producer prices declined by 2.8% in February 2026 compared to February 2025, reaching an index level of 117.2. In the first two months of 2026, chemical prices averaged 117.0, down 0.8% compared to the same period in 2025.

Chemical prices fell more sharply than total manufacturing, which remained broadly stable at 0.2% year-on-year. Among industrial sectors, basic metals experienced the steepest price increases at 8.8%, while pharmaceuticals rose by 1.9% and motor vehicles by 0.9%.

The Netherlands experienced the steepest price decline at 9.2%, followed by Belgium (5.5%) and France (3.0%). Germany reported a 1.7% decrease, while Spain matched the EU27 average at 2.8%. Italy posted the smallest decline at 0.3%. Poland decreased by 1.9%.



Source: Cefic analysis based on Eurostat data (2026)



Source: Cefic analysis based on Eurostat data (2026)

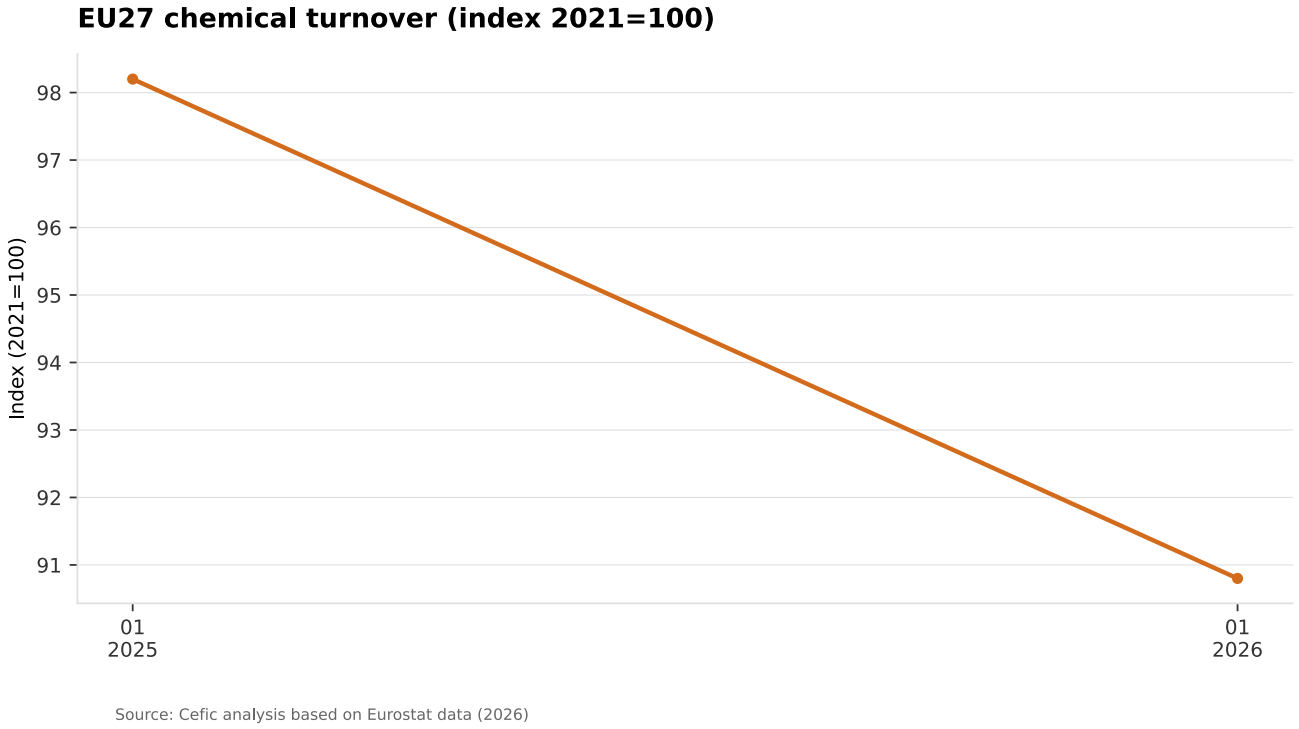
EU27 chemical sales down 7.5% in January 2026

EU27 chemical sales fell by 7.5% in January 2026 compared to January 2025, with the index reaching 90.8 (2021=100). The decline outpaced total manufacturing, which decreased by 1.8% over the same period.

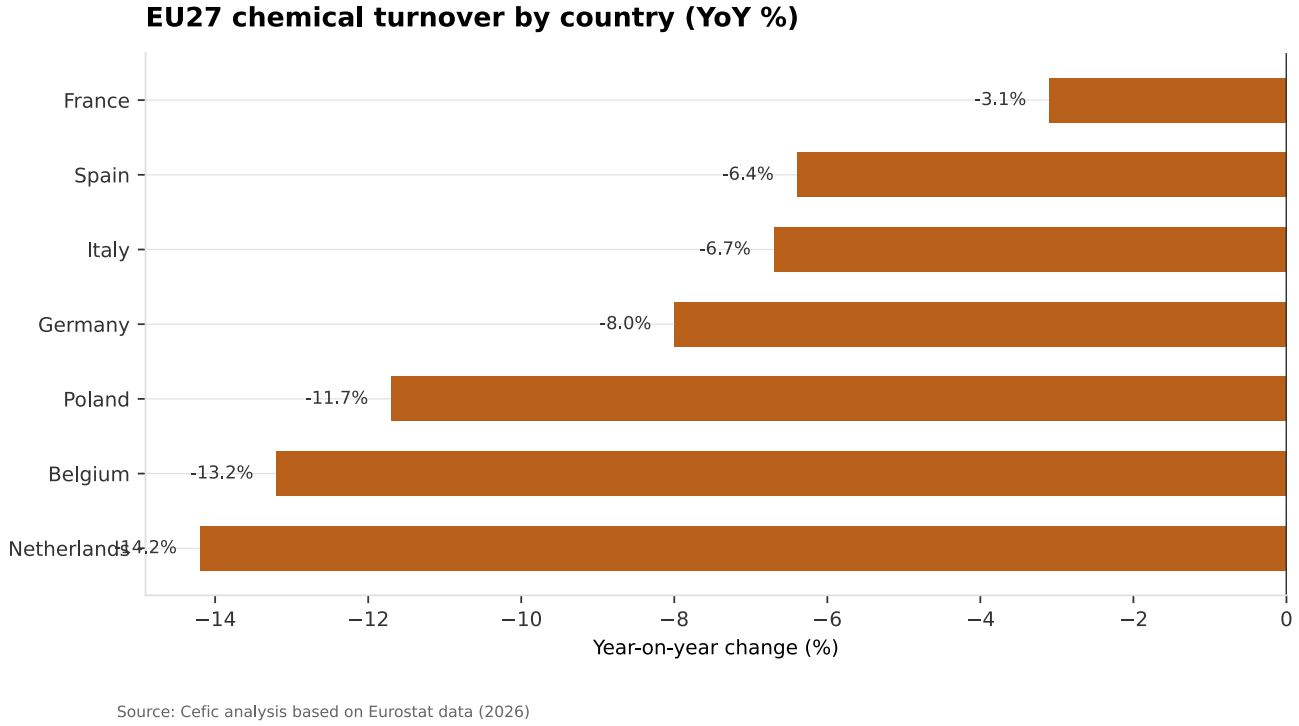
Germany experienced the steepest decline at 8.0%, followed by the Netherlands (14.2%) and Belgium (13.2%). France reported the smallest decrease at 3.1%, while Poland fell by 11.7%. Italy and Spain posted declines of 6.7%

and 6.4% respectively.

Among manufacturing sectors, pharmaceuticals recorded the largest drop at 24.4%, while motor vehicles and basic metals gained 4.9% and 4.7% respectively. These chemical sales trends by country show a fragmented Europe.



Source: Cefic analysis based on Eurostat data (2026)



Source: Cefic analysis based on Eurostat data (2026)

EU27 chemical exports fall 42% in February, distorted by anomalous 2025 base

From January to February 2026, EU27 chemical exports decreased by 42.1% in value in comparison to the same period in 2025, a figure heavily influenced by an anomalous February 2025 base. Exports amounted to €34.5 bn in the first two months of 2026, down by €25.1 bn compared to 2025.

This figure reflects an unusually high base in February 2025, driven by pre-tariff front-loading ahead of US trade measures. EU exports to the US averaged €22.3 bn per month in the preceding 12 months but spiked to €31.6 bn in February 2025, 4.8 standard deviations above the rolling mean. Against a normal base (February 2024), exports are down by approximately 10%, a more representative indication of the underlying trend.

EU27 chemical exports fell by 17.4% in volume and 42.1% in value between January-February 2025 and January-February 2026, reflecting a shift toward lower-value categories and unit price compression.

Exports to the United States decreased by €9.4 bn (72.5%), driven by 29371900 (heterocyclic compounds) (€8.2 bn decline) and 29335995 (heterocyclic compounds, pyrimidine/piperazine ring) (€0.4 bn decline). The largest current flow remains 29349990 (heterocyclic compounds) (€0.5 bn, 13% of the total).

Exports to the United Kingdom increased by €0.1 bn (4.9%), driven by 28442035 (inorganic compounds) (€0.2 bn gain) and 29335995 (heterocyclic compounds, pyrimidine/piperazine ring) (€0.03 bn gain). The largest current flow remains 28442035 (inorganic compounds) (€0.3 bn, 13% of the total).

Exports to China decreased by €0.1 bn (7.3%), driven by 38180010 (chemical elements and compounds) (€0.04 bn decline) and 38221900 (diagnostic or laboratory reagents) (€0.02 bn decline). The largest current flow remains 33049900 (beauty or make-up preparations) (€0.1 bn, 10% of the total).

With €3.5 bn, organic chemicals is the largest export chapter of the EU27 area for chemicals, followed by essential oils and resinoids (€3.6 bn) and miscellaneous chemical products (€3.1 bn). Organic chemicals fell 77.5% compared to February 2025, while inorganic chemicals gained 25%.

Source: Cefic analysis based on Eurostat data (2026)

EU27 chemical imports fell 12% in value in the first two months of 2026

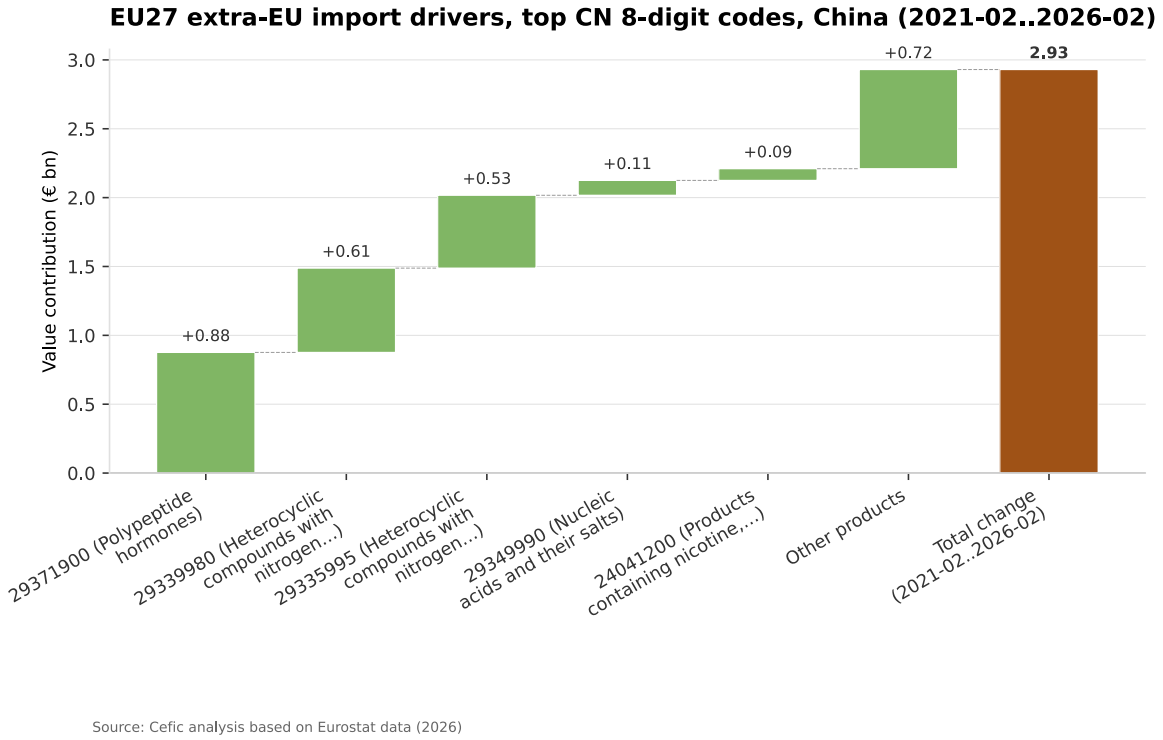
From January to February 2026, EU27 chemical imports decreased by 12.0% in value in comparison to the same period in 2025. EU27 chemical imports amounted to €33.5 bn in the first two months of 2026, down by €4.6 bn compared to 2025. In volume terms, imports fell by 18.5%, reflecting a shift toward higher-value categories despite lower average unit prices.

Imports from China increased by 4.8% to €4.4 bn in February 2026, driven by polypeptide hormones (€0.9 bn) and other organic basic chemicals (€1.5 bn). Basic pharmaceutical products accounted for 41% of Chinese imports, followed by other organic basic chemicals at 35%. The largest current flow remains polypeptide hormones (€0.9 bn, 20% of the total).

Imports from the United States rose by 4.7% to €3.7 bn, led by polypeptide hormones (€1.5 bn) and diagnostic or laboratory reagents (€0.3 bn). Basic pharmaceutical products represented 46% of US imports, with other organic basic chemicals at 18%. Polypeptide hormones alone explain 439% of the net variation in US imports.

Imports from the United Kingdom declined by 13.3% to €1.5 bn in February 2026, driven by mineral fuels (down €0.1 bn) and polyethylene products (down €0.0 bn). The flow is more diversified than other key partners, with other organic basic chemicals, other chemical products, and other inorganic basic chemicals each representing 16% of UK imports.

With 5 CN chapters accounting for 73% of imports, the product base shows moderate concentration. Organic chemicals remained the largest import category at €9.2 bn, virtually unchanged from 2025 (down 0.3%). Miscellaneous chemical products fell by 9.1% to €1.8 bn, while plastics and articles thereof dropped by 18.4% to €1.6 bn.



Source: Cefic analysis based on Eurostat data (2026)

SOURCES AND METHODOLOGY

Data source. Eurostat Short-Term Business Statistics (production, prices, turnover), seasonally adjusted where available. Trade flows from Comext (EU27 external trade), extra-EU only, declarant=EU, flow exports=2 and imports=1.

Scope. NACE C20 chemicals for industrial indicators; Comext chapters 27-40 filtered by the Cefic chemistry product map for trade.

Window conventions. YoY (year-on-year), YTD (year-to-date, first N months of the current year vs same window of the prior year), pre-crisis baseline averages 2014-2019. Index base: 2021=100 unless otherwise stated.

Anomalies. When the comparison base is distorted (Z-score above 2 sigma against the 12-month rolling mean, or bilateral concentration above 75% of absolute variation), the section carries an explicit base-effect caveat.

Publication. Iris is a monthly Cefic publication. Past editions and methodology details at cefic.org.